He doubled down on those comments in an interview with the *Daily Telegraph* , in which he observed, ‘What happened in the past is history.’ To be fair, he stressed he had no jurisdiction in matters of selection, but he urged readers to ‘forget personalities. Selectors pick the best players in form, taking wickets and scoring runs. That is their job.’

Taken alongside a comment that, if KP scored really heavily, ‘they can’t ignore him, I would have thought’, it gave Kevin his chance to shine. He was without a county at the time, having signed to play in the IPL and Caribbean Premier League, but within a couple of hours of the original interview he had told Sky TV he valued the potential opportunity.

He, too, doubled down in the *Telegraph* , where he was quoted as saying: ‘Do I want to play for England again? Yes, of course I do. My time with England was cut short and I have always said I want to play again.’ He promised to talk to Graves, a successful businessman who, in true Yorkshire tradition, evidently specialized in plain speaking.

That trait had already complicated my captaincy, since he described the West Indies as ‘mediocre’. It was an unnecessarily provocative comment that led to the question ‘Are we mediocre?’ being plastered, in large letters, across their dressing-room wall. I had been looked after marvellously by the ECB for most of my career, but I didn’t think an administrator of his stature should not have used such language.

I felt aggrieved that I was expected to suck it up and carry on regardless. Moores talked me round and, freed up mentally by the knowledge that my relationship with Strauss was about to be reinforced following the sacking of Paul Downton, I scored my first Test century in just under two years, 105, in the first innings of the frenetic final Test in Barbados.

We lost, from a winning position, in three days and squandered the chance to take the series. That century had significance beyond its immediate inadequacy, because it was such a personal achievement, and I was distracted when asked in a post-match radio interview about the ‘mediocre’ comment. ‘That’s a Yorkshireman for you,’ I said jokingly. ‘They’re quite happy to talk a good game.’

It’s fair to say this didn’t go down well with Geoffrey Boycott. I didn’t know him that well but had huge respect for him as a defining voice of cricket, and one of the best batsmen of his era. We often discussed the intricacies of the game, and laughed easily at his favourite line, ‘If I had a daughter, I’d let you marry her.’